

certainly a big factor in their decision to hire you. Are you sold on its vitality? Ok moving on.

Your portfolio tells a story. It shows clients why you should be hired and what to expect. Treat it with utmost importance and care. Spend time on it and think about it as a paid work for a client. Market yourself carefully and update your portfolio on a regular basis. Now let's get into the nitty gritty of building a portfolio. How to go about it? Should you use a portfolio hosting site online or create your own website? The biggest question of all – what's to be done if you are just starting out and have no body of work to showcase? Fear not intrepid Digit readers, all of your questions will soon be answered.

We will first tackle the problem of portfolio building as a newbie. You are most likely facing a Catch-22 situation – how to create a portfolio with no or few clients and how to get clients and more work without a portfolio. You can create an awesome portfolio even with very few pieces of work to show for or even when you have no clients. When you have no clients, shift your perspective a bit. You do have one client – yourself. Think of a project that you would like to do and hire yourself to complete it. Assign deadlines, write out a project brief and client expectations. Work on it and ensure that you deliver it within the deadline and to the best of your ability. Once completed, you can use this as a body of work for your portfolio.

Another method, albeit an unpopular one, is doing some small, free work. Remember the keyword small. Since it's free and you are doing it build up your portfolio, don't undertake a byzantine task that will take eons to complete. Approach some local businesses and offer your services. Don't sound desperate, just let them know that an aspect of their business is missing a vital part and you can fill the gap for free. Instead of saying that you are the first client, you can say that you are looking to specialise in this area and build your portfolio. Make sure that they understand you already have specialised knowledge in this area and are not a complete newbie.

Talk about your previous work experience, educational background and how you gained this skill set. Once they are convinced, define the scope of the project. This is extremely important since you don't want to be saddled with a never ending project and seemingly minor one that just got snowballed into a year-long thankless job. Lastly but not the least, get a credit to your name and if possible a testimonial from the client. Another important point is to make sure that the client can give you a referral to another job that actually pays. Maybe you want to approach the CTO of some IT company to get a gig. One of your mutual connections on LinkedIn has a startup that you can